

WINGS OF FIRE

An Autobiography

AVUL PAKIR JAINULABDEEN ABDUL KALAM has come to personal y represent to many of his countrymen the best aspects of Indian life. Born in 1931, the son of a little educated boatowner in Rameswaram, Tamilnadu, he had an unparal eled career as a defence scientist, culminating in the highest civilian award of India, the Bharat Ratna.

As chief of the country's defence research and development programme, Kalam demonstrated the great potential for dynamism and innovation that existed in seemingly moribund research establishments. This is the story of Kalam's rise from obscurity and his personal and professional struggles, as wel as the story of *Agni, Prithvi, Akash, Trishul* a n d *Nag* - missiles that have become household names in India and that have raised the nation to the level of a missile power of international recokoning.

At the same time as he has helped create India's awesome weaponry, Kalam has maintained the ascetic